due to a number of political and commercial factors in India, Iran, and the international environment.

The Taliban's sweeping return to power in 2021 initially placed India at a disadvantage. India had been excluded from dialogue by the United States and played a peripheral role in parallel discussions sponsored by Russia, in part due to Pakistan's necessary role in bringing the Taliban to the negotiating table. But despite Pakistani triumphalism, embodied in the appearance of the ISI chief in Kabul shortly after its takeover by the Taliban, cracks began to appear between the Taliban and Pakistan. India, despite supporting factions of the Northern Alliance in their escape to Tajikistan, sought to take advantage of these differences, and continue its engagement with Kabul under the new Taliban dispensation. It gradually reopened its embassy and continued providing technical assistance and food aid. Meanwhile, relations between Afghanistan and Pakistan deteriorated further, with firing across their border. Despite concerns about the Taliban's treatment of minorities and women, the lack of formal diplomatic recognition, and continuing security complications (which initially prevented India from issuing visas for Afghan refugees and students), India has found a way to engage the new leadership in Kabul.

Nonetheless, geography and other factors constrain the potential role that India can play in Afghanistan. Working to improve connectivity, particularly via Iran and Tajikistan, will be necessary. But the contours of Afghanistan's future are still very unclear. Divisions and factions remain within the Taliban, and the security situation is still precarious in places. Questions around the Taliban's diplomatic recognition, a new Constitution, and the status of minorities remain uncertain. Despite these complications, continuing Indian involvement to ensure that its larger security and regional objectives are met will remain important.

Priority 11. Reshape the Middle East

Beyond Pakistan and Afghanistan, there are larger and perhaps more important dynamics underway in West Asia, a region in which India has